

Politics in the Writing Classroom

A Reader for Graduate Teaching Associates

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Dear Colleagues,

The following readings are designed to help you think about the challenges presented by difficult or loaded issues in the composition classroom. The composition classroom can be a politicized space, with students wanting to engage issues that are important to them and express their perspectives as best they can—that's what we're in the classroom to help them to do. The classroom is not and should not be a site of indoctrination. As teachers, our role is to help students improve, not to judge whether we approve of their politics: assess the writing, not the opinions. Yet, as the accompanying readings suggest, that isn't always easy.

The readings take up the difficulty from different directions. James Berlin argues that no way of teaching writing is ideologically innocent, and Maxine Hairston answers that a course that puts the teacher's politics first shortchanges students' development as writers; together they frame a debate composition studies has never fully settled. Min-Zhan Lu argues that conflict is less something to protect students from than the place where much of their learning begins. Richard Miller brings the problem down to the desk: a student paper describing a violent homophobic attack, and the question of how to respond to it as writing. Joseph Harris proposes that difference in the classroom can work less like a battle and more like a negotiation. Karen Kopelson closes the set by treating neutrality not as a teacher's natural position but as a performance, one that can be used strategically, especially by teachers whose authority students are already inclined to question. None of them offers a formula, but together they may help you decide what kind of instructor you want to be when a loaded issue lands.

Contents

1. Berlin, James. "Rhetoric and Ideology in the Writing Class." *College English*, vol. 50, no. 5, 1988, pp. 477–94.

Berlin examines the three rhetorics he finds most conspicuous in classroom practice—cognitive, expressionistic, and social-epistemic—and asks what ideology each carries into the classroom, since "a rhetoric can never be innocent." He forwards social-epistemic rhetoric as the alternative that makes "the very question of ideology the center of classroom activities." If every writing class teaches a way of seeing, should the teacher say which one?

2. Hairston, Maxine. "Diversity, Ideology, and Teaching Writing." *College Composition and Communication*, vol. 43, no. 2, 1992, pp. 179–93.

A past chair of CCCC, Hairston charges that politically focused writing courses put "dogma before diversity, politics before craft," and "the social goals of the teacher before the educational needs of the student." Her chief example is a course on racism and sexism proposed at the University of Texas at Austin in 1990. She offers the alternative that "real diversity emerges from the students themselves," in a collaborative classroom where they develop their ideas and test them on each other.

3. Lu, Min-Zhan. "Conflict and Struggle: The Enemies or Preconditions of Basic Writing?" *College English*, vol. 54, no. 8, 1992, pp. 887–913.

Lu traces the view that conflict and struggle are "the enemies of Basic Writing" to three of the field's pioneers, Kenneth Bruffee, Thomas Farrell, and Mina Shaughnessy, who treated students' fear of acculturation, and the contradictions they felt between home and academy, as a deficit to be cured. Drawing on Gloria Anzaldúa's account of life in the borderlands, she argues that teachers should instead draw on students' experience of conflict as "a constructive resource." Where Berlin and Hairston argue over the teacher's politics, Lu moves the question to the student's.

4. Miller, Richard E. "Fault Lines in the Contact Zone." *College English*, vol. 56, no. 4, 1994, pp. 389–408.

Miller asks what Mary Louise Pratt's "pedagogical arts of the contact zone" would look like in practice, centering on a student's account of a violent homophobic attack written for Scott Lankford's community-college writing class. When Lankford brought the essay to CCCC, the most popular responses read it as fact and would have turned the student over to a counselor or the police; Lankford, an openly gay instructor, had instead responded to it as if it were a fictional short story. Miller calls the result "the kind of partial, imperfect, negotiated, microvictory available to those who work in the contact zone": the student stayed in the course and later signed up for another with Lankford.

5. Harris, Joseph. "Negotiating the Contact Zone." *Journal of Basic Writing*, vol. 14, no. 1, 1995, pp. 27–42.

Harris doubts the contact zone's image of "cultures banging or sliding or bouncing off each other" and argues for "a more expansive view of intellectual life" than it offers. Building on Miller's case, he argues that with students whose beliefs are "simply opposed to our own," we "need first to find ways of keeping them an active part of the conversation of the class."

6. Kopelson, Karen. "Rhetoric on the Edge of Cunning; Or, the Performance of Neutrality (Re)Considered as a Composition Pedagogy for Student Resistance." *College Composition and Communication*, vol. 55, no. 1, 2003, pp. 115–46.

Kopelson argues that overtly politicized pedagogies "may only exacerbate student resistance," especially when the teacher is already "marked or read as different," as women, teachers of color, and queer teachers often are. Her answer draws on metis, the Greek rhetorical art of cunning: the strategic performance of the very neutrality students expect of their teachers, a way to engage difference "more efficaciously, if more sneakily."

Further Reading

Bérubé, Michael. *What's Liberal About the Liberal Arts? Classroom Politics and "Bias" in Higher Education.*

Duffy, John. *Provocations of Virtue: Rhetoric, Ethics, and the Teaching of Writing.*

Durst, Russel K. *Collision Course: Conflict, Negotiation, and Learning in College Composition.*

Fish, Stanley. *Save the World on Your Own Time.*

Miller, Richard E. *Writing at the End of the World.*

Roberts-Miller, Patricia. *Deliberate Conflict: Argument, Political Theory, and Composition Classes.*